GUEST COLUMN



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New PM Liz Truss with Rishi Sunak

The United Kingdom, one of the world's oldest functioning democracies, on September 6 witnessed the completion of an unusual internal political process: the ruling Conservatives elected ex-foreign secretary Liz Truss as the UK's next Prime Minister—the fourth in six years.

It all started two months ago, when over 60 cabinet colleagues of former Prime Minister Boris Johnson resigned en masse, forcing his resignation on July 7. Through several rounds of voting in later weeks, Conservative Party MPs zeroed in on two candidates for the post of party leader: Rishi Sunak, ex-Chancellor of the Exchequer, and Truss. Through the hottest summer Britain has experienced in 138 years, the two then competed for majority support of the party membership. The contest was close: Sunak initially enjoyed a good lead, but Truss's promise to introduce lower taxes, stabilise prices and navigate the British economy to calmer waters seems to have had greater appeal—about 57 per cent plumped for her.

Truss will lead the party into the next election in 2024. Her immediate priority, though, will be to fulfil her promise of drawing up a 'plan'—within a week—to tackle the worst cost of living crisis the UK has seen since the 1950s. She has promised to 'cap' the price of gas and electricity and safeguard the British economy through the slowdown, while protecting local businesses and services struggling with post-pandemic recovery.

What can India expect from the new British PM? Truss is no stranger to India. As trade secretary, she engaged on the minutiae of tariffs and concessions during talks to eliminate or significantly reduce customs duties on goods traded between India and the UK. India's exports to the UK range from readymade garments to machinery, pharma and marine and agricultural produce. Its imports from the UK include ores, engineering goods, chemicals, non-ferrous metals, etc.

The full implementation of the Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreement, signed on May 4, 2021, is also a top priority. The deal envisages, inter alia, bespoke measures to ease movement of students and professionals between India and the UK.

As foreign secretary, Truss has valued her engagement with external affairs minister S. Jaishankar. They have consulted frankly on regional and global developments. Delegation-level talks have also been robust and comprehensive. On one occasion, as Truss tried to grasp the contours of a matter related to the India House property at Aldwych, London, she spontaneously offered to drop by at the Indian Mission to understand, first-hand, the facts of the case. In her presentations at Policy Exchange, a premier think-tank in London, Truss's perspective of a global Britain entering into strong trade ties with India and our region has been consistent and clear.

Truss is no stranger to India. As trade secretary, she headed the talks on tariff concessions. It's a robust partnership

In March 2021, the Johnson government presented a once-in-a-generation integrated review of the UK's foreign and security policies, setting out the country's vision till 2025. It prioritised engagement with India in a range of sectors. The India-UK Roadmap to 2030, the first such initiative by the UK with any country, fosters agreed action and initiatives in diverse sectors ranging from space, defence and security to technology sharing, and closer cooperation in education, research and cultural exchanges.

India and the UK have worked